



Stone age tools

Check out some innovative implements made by our ancestors in this gallery by Smithsonian. <https://digit.in/jul20-53>



Early human societies

This course by Khan Academy explores early human technology, culture, society and daily life. <https://digit.in/jul20-54>

just a form of creative expression. Maybe they were whiteboards, used to teach the behavior of animals and techniques for hunting to a new generation of hunters. Those who want to learn more about cave paintings can watch the documentary *Cave of Forgotten Dreams* by Werner Herzog.

Along with information on how to use tools, making clothes, what kind of species to hunt, and what kind of foodstuff to forage, it is almost certain that humans were also telling stories, Accounts of hunts maybe, or stories of beasts and monsters, or ancient deluges beyond the memories of any of the living. These early stories are the origins of mythologies around the world, and scholars have noted many similarities among them. However, to tell the stories and to transmit the information itself, it was necessary for language to evolve, which is another crucial component of culture.

THE ORIGIN OF LANGUAGE

There are a number of theories on the origin of language, and scientists cannot really agree on any one of them. All the theories have funny sounding names, the kind of words that are used to talk with infants or fur babies. The oldest is perhaps the ding-dong theory suggested by Plato, suggests that words came up from essential aspects of the thing being described, such as boom for an explosion or oink for a pig. However, there is flimsy evidence that there is an innate link between what a word sounds like and what it means. The bow-wow theory is that language originated when humans started imitating the sounds of animals that they saw around them. Maybe they used mock bird calls to coordinate attacks during hunts. Linguists have pointed out though that dog barks are different in various languages, it is a woof in English, a haf in American, a kong in Balinese, a gheu in Bengali, an auh in Estonian a guk in Indonesian, an amh in Irish, a meong in Korean, and a gav in Russian. The la-la theory is that language came out

of a desire for humans to express love, and to sing. According to this theory, humans began to sing love ballads before they had the words to describe what they were feeling. According to the pooh-pooh theory, language originated from natural responses, such as saying “aaargh” when a caveman crunches up his little toe against the cave opening, or a caveman shouting “woohoo!” when a mammoth falls into a trap. Then we have the yo-he-ho, according to which language evolved from the natural groans and sounds of humans doing hard labour, such as pulling out a stubborn root from the ground, or hauling up the carcass of a mammoth from a trap.

HOMO LUDENS

It is actually quite difficult to pinpoint a single characteristic that separates humans from animals. We are named *Homo sapiens* because we can apparently think, but a wide range of creatures from octopi to parrots have demonstrated their abilities to think as well. The use of tools also does not distinguish us because crows, chimpanzees and dolphins are just some of the creatures that are known to use tools. According to a book called *Homo ludens* by J Huizinga, it is man's inclination to play games that actually distinguishes him the most from other creatures, and that this aspect of humans needs to be examined with more academic seriousness. Considering the nature of play, Huizinga says that just how important play has been to the formation of human culture has been historically undervalued, “The fact that play and culture are actually interwoven with one another was neither observed nor expressed, whereas for us the whole point is to show that genuine, pure play is

one of the main bases of civilisation”. Now playing itself is seen in the animal kingdom, bear cubs and wolf pups play, at times rough and bloody sport. This demonstrates that play originated before humans did. According to Huizinga, “Man only plays when in the full meaning of the word he is a man, and he is only completely a man when he plays.”

The Latin word *ludo*, means a whole bunch of things which does not have a direct English translation, and encompasses the ideas of sport, play, school and practice. The book goes on to show how play is an essential component for our language, poetry, art, theatrical productions and music. Even more serious things such as le-



A group of Marwari men playing Pacheesi

gal proceedings may have an element of play, like the wigs worn by the judges or the apparel of the lawyers which transforms them into different creatures, similar to the masks worn by the shamans of old. There is some controversy on the publication in how the word “of” and “in” are used. While Huizinga, in the foreword itself tries to make it clear that his work is about the play element of culture, the editors felt that considering English prepositions are not as logical as Dutch ones, translated it to the play element in culture. The main takeaway is that play is a primary and necessary component of the formation of human culture. ■

Source: Columbia University/ eBay/ Taurines?